



Study Notes

Active Passive Voice

ACTIVE AND PASSIVE VOICE

In a sentence, when the subject acts, the verb is said to be in Active Voice, but when the subject is passive and receives action, the verb is said to be in Passive Voice.

e. g.

a) Sachin plays football.

This sentence indicates that the subject 'Sachin' does something. So, it is in Active Voice.

b) Football is played by Sachin.

In this sentence, the verb 'played' indicates that something is done by Sachin. So, the verb here is in Passive Voice.

Note:

- a) Voice changes occur only in transitive verbs.
- b) The perfect continuous form of all the three tenses and future continuous cannot be changed into passive voice.

In order to convert active voice into passive voice, certain rules need to be observed.

1. First of all, the arrangement of the words in a sentence in the active voice is changed.

Active Voice: Subject + Verb + Object

Chintu writes a book.

Passive Voice:

Object + helping verb + main verb + by + subject

A book is written by Chintu.

Thus, the subject of the active voice becomes the object of the passive voice.

2. Change of Pronoun

- a) When 'he' as subject of active voice becomes object of the passive voice, it changes into 'him'.
Similarly,
- b) 'She' becomes 'her',
c) 'We' becomes 'us',
d) 'They' becomes 'them',
e) 'I' becomes 'me',

3. Changes required under each tense

Tense	Active Voice	Passive Voice
Simple Present	Rohan breaks the vase.	The vase is broken by Rohan.
	Does Rohan break the vase ?	Is the vase broken by Rohan ?
Present Continuous	Rohan is breaking the vase .	The vase is being broken by Rohan.
	Is Rohan breaking the vase .	Is the vase being broken by Rohan?
Present Perfect	Rohan has broken the vase.	The vase has been broken by Rohan.
	Has Rohan broken the vase ?	Has the vase been broken by Rohan ?
Simple Past	Rohan broke the vase.	The vase was broken by Rohan.
	Did Rohan break the vase ?	Was the vase broken by Rohan ?
Past Continuous	Rohan was breaking the vase	The vase was being broken by Rohan.
	Was Rohan breaking the vase?	Was the vase being broken by Rohan ?
Past Perfect	Rohan had broken the vase.	The vase had been broken by Rohan.
	Had Rohan broken the vase ?	Had the vase been broken by Rohan ?
Simple Future	Rohan will break the vase.	The vase will be broken by Rohan.
	Will Rohan break the vase.	Will the vase be broken by Rohan.
Future Perfect	Rohan will have broken the vase?	The vase will have been broken by Rohan?
	Will Rohan have broken the vase?	Will the vase have been broken by Rohan?

Other Examples for changing active voice into Passive Voice

a) Modal Auxiliaries: Can, may, could, might, should, must, ought to, etc, do not change when transformed to passive voice from active voice.

Examples:

- Rohan can kick the ball. (Active Voice)

The ball can be kicked by Rohan. (Passive Voice)

- The participants ought to follow the instructions. (Active Voice)

The Instructions ought to be followed by the participants. (Passive Voice)

- They should invite the Prime Minister. (Active Voice)

The prime Minister should be invited by them. (Passive Voice)

b) The preposition after a verb in the active voice does not change its place in the passive voice.

Examples:

- Rita laughed at the boy. (Active Voice)

The boy was laughed at by Rita. (Passive Voice)

- He has not heard of this incident. (Active Voice)

This incident has not been heard of by him. (Passive Voice)

- Your parents will object to your seeing this movie. (Active Voice)

Your seeing this movie will be objected to by your parents. (Passive Voice)

c) Participles in Passive construction.

Examples:

- I saw him beating the boy. (Active Voice)

I saw the boy being beaten by him. (Passive Voice)

- I heard her knocking at the door. (Active Voice)

I heard the door being knocked at by her. (Passive Voice).

d) Imperatives in passive construction.

Examples:

- Switch off the radio. (Active Voice)

Let the radio be switched off. (Passive Voice)

- Bring the letters. (Active Voice)

Let the letters be brought. (Passive Voice)

- Please forgive me. (Active Voice)

You are requested to forgive me. (Passive Voice)

- Obey your parents. (Active Voice)

You are advised to obey your parents. (Passive Voice)

Note: All imperatives except requests use “let” in passive constructions. “Please” becomes “you are requested to” in passive.

An important point to remember is that when we change imperative sentences from active to passive voice, “let” should be used in case of non-living things and animals. In case of human beings, it is more appropriate to use “should”.

Active and Passive Voice

For example:

- Give the blankets. (Active Voice)

Let the blankets be given. (Passive Voice)

- Feed the dogs. (Active Voice)

Let the dogs be fed. (Passive Voice)

- Don't laugh at the poor. (Active Voice)

The poor should not be laughed at. (Passive Voice)

- Take care of your grandfather. (Active Voice)

Your grandfather should be taken care of. (Passive Voice)

Request, advise, order are used only when

- Imperative sentences have intransitive verbs; as,

- Post the letters. (Active Voice)

You are requested to post the letters. (Passive Voice)

- Sentences whose object is not mentioned; as,

- Please withdraw. (Active Voice)

You are requested to withdraw. (Passive Voice)

e) Some other passive constructions.

Examples:

- People say that she is a divorcee. (Active Voice)

It is said that she is a divorcee. (Passive Voice)

- She is said to be a divorcee. (Passive Voice)

Everyone knows that he is a criminal. (Active Voice)

- It is known that he is a criminal. (Passive Voice)

He is known to be a criminal. (Passive Voice)